C M Y K

Nxxx,2026-10-23,A,001,Bs-4C,E1

"All the News That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, sunshine, a light breeze, high 57. **Tonight,** clear, variable winds, low 45. **Tomorrow,** sunny to partly cloudy, variable winds, high 59. Weather map appears on Page A22.

VOL. CLXXVI .... No. 61,046 © 2026 The New York Times Company FRIDAY, OCTOBER 23, 2026 Prices in Canada may be higher $4.00



JEENAH MOON/REUTERS

New York City moved closer on Thursday to a ban on horse carriages in Central Park. The effort gained steam after a tourist's death.

165 Years On, A Vote to Stop The Clip-Clop

By ED SHANAHAN and DANA RUBINSTEIN

The New York City Council voted on Thursday to banish horse-drawn carriages from Central Park in two years, setting the stage for the elimination of an attraction as old as the park itself.

The Council vote on the bill imposing the ban was a definitive, if not final, step toward ending a politically contentious debate over the future of the carriage industry, which some people criticize as a form of animal cruelty with no place in a crowded park and others embrace as a vestige of old-world charm.

Mayor Zohran Mamdani's office helped craft the bill, which passed 40 to 7, a veto-proof margin.

"The mayor will sign this bill, and the Mamdani administration is working every day to ensure we can do so while providing the strongest possible protections for the owners and workers in this industry," said Sneha Choudhary, a spokeswoman for Mr. Mamdani.

The legislation dictates that horse carriages will not be allowed to operate in the city as of June 2028, but it includes few concrete details about how the city will address the economic fallout of eliminating the industry for the roughly 200 owners, drivers and stablehands whose livelihoods are tied to it. The bill is also vague on what will become of the 180 car-

Continued on Page A19

El-Sayed Confronts Attacks on Faith and Family

Spotlight on Identity as He Runs to Be First Muslim Senator

*This article is by **Reid J. Epstein**, **Brian M. Rosenthal** and **Michael Kruse**.*

In the final weeks of Michigan's closely watched Senate race, Dr. Abdul El-Sayed's ethnicity, religion and family have come under renewed attacks and scrutiny.

His Republican opponent, former Representative Mike Rogers, invoked Dr. El-Sayed's mother during their first debate, trying to draw a connection between her and Al Qaeda. President Trump has mocked the pronunciation of Dr. El-Sayed's name and has started referring to him by his middle name, Mohamed. And Republican ads have suggested that Dr. El-Sayed has ties to terrorist groups or to the Muslim Brotherhood, the Islamist political movement.

Dr. El-Sayed has forcefully responded to the questions about his identity. Over the weekend, a nearly five-minute exchange at a town-hall event with a man who asked him to "disavow the Muslim Brotherhood" went viral on social media. This week, in a brief, testy interaction with a reporter from Newsmax, he said, "I clearly disavow" the movement. And in a new video, Dr. El-Sayed says that he prays daily and calls himself a "man of faith."

Now Dr. El-Sayed, who would be the first Muslim senator if he wins, finds himself confronting both ugly attacks and pointed

Continued on Page A16



ZBIGNIEW BZDAK FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

"We kind of all knew where this was headed," said Dr. Abdul El-Sayed, a Democrat in Michigan.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Putin Nearing Revived Links With the U.S.

Big Goal: Conceding Nothing on Ukraine

By VALERIE HOPKINS

BERLIN — Last October, President Trump imposed significant sanctions on Russia's two largest oil companies, complaining that negotiations with President Vladimir V. Putin over ending the war in Ukraine "just don't go anywhere."

A red-carpet welcome for the Russian leader in Alaska had done nothing to bring peace. A planned summit in Budapest had fallen apart. Mr. Trump had started to acknowledge that Mr. Putin might just be playing him, with no intention of making peace. Faint Ukrainian hopes glimmered of a Trump-Putin break.

But the Russian president was playing a longer game.

Now, exactly a year after the oil sanctions, Mr. Putin has never been so close to his goal of normalizing relations with Washington without having to make any compromises on Ukraine.

Over the past week and a half, Mr. Trump has set aside years of U.S. foreign policy by openly embracing Mr. Putin and easing the economic pressure on the Kremlin. At the same time, Mr. Trump has vilified President Volodymyr Zelensky of Ukraine, the putative American ally trying to defend his nation against a Russian invasion.

On Oct. 9, Mr. Trump announced that the United States would buy Russian diesel, asking for no concessions from Mr. Putin in return. The Trump administration went on to pressure Ukraine to stop striking oil refineries — Kyiv's most powerful lever — and suspended Russia sanctions that Mr. Trump had just signed into law. Mr. Trump declared that "Russia, frankly, has been fine on Ukraine."

The diesel deal was in part a political calculation by Mr. Trump before the midterm elections, as he tries to lower fuel prices. But that action and others that followed also reflect the president's long-evident affinity for Mr. Putin, which the Russian leader has assiduously cultivated even while continuing the war and denying Mr. Trump a coveted prize.

Continued on Page A6

U.S. AND ISRAELIS DRAWING UP PLAN FOR IRAN ATTACKS

AFTER THE MIDTERMS

Awaiting Trump's OK — U.S. Hopes Tehran Is Forced to Give In

*This article is by **Julian E. Barnes**, **Eric Schmitt**, **Farnaz Fassihi**, **Natan Odenheimer** and **Ronen Bergman**.*

WASHINGTON — The U.S. and Israeli militaries have developed specific plans for renewed strikes against Iran after the American midterm elections, according to U.S. officials and other people briefed on the deliberations.

As planning for a short but intensive operation progresses, the U.S. and Israeli militaries have stepped up exercises, flying planes over Iraq to practice strike maneuvers. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth met with Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in Israel this week to discuss new strikes, U.S. officials said.

The targets would likely include Iran's energy infrastructure, nuclear facilities, and missile and drone arsenal. Some officials say one more big round of attacks could push Iran's economy over the brink and force the country to make diplomatic concessions after nearly eight months of conflict.

Still, there are reasons to be skeptical that a renewed war would be any more successful than the first phase of intense U.S.-Israeli strikes between February and April. Those rounds of fighting drove up energy prices and inflation around the world, eroded security in the Middle East and severely strained the Pentagon's supply of missile interceptors.

It is also far from certain Mr. Trump will approve fresh strikes. Repeatedly this year he has vetoed plans for a return to major combat operations, including this month when the U.S. and Israeli militaries were nearly ready to attack.

All of the officials interviewed for this article spoke on the condition of anonymity to candidly discuss military planning.

Iranian officials have promised to retaliate this time by expanding their targets beyond commercial ships and energy infrastructure in the region to data centers and underwater internet cables.

Continued on Page A9

Overseas Israelis Could Swing Votes Away From Netanyahu

Traveling Back Home for a Tight Election

*This article is by **Yair Rosenberg**, **Debra Kamin** and **Gabby Sobelman**.*

Bar Luzon, an Israeli citizen living in Cambridge, Mass., never considered herself "a political person." An assistant professor of linguistics and philosophy at M.I.T., she had not voted in an Israeli election since she came to the United States for graduate school eight years ago. But after the events of Oct. 7, 2023, she said, she could no longer sit on the sidelines.

"It feels like the country is not functioning, in a scary way," Ms. Luzon, 32, said. She cited Israel's failure to quickly stop the Hamas-led attack, a lack of vision beyond "war until the end of times" and recent efforts to ban Arab parties from the upcoming elections. "I'm very afraid of how racist my government is, how much it hates its own citizens," she said.

She now plans to vote against Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his allies when Israelis go to the polls on Tuesday. But there's a catch. Unlike many democracies, Israel does not allow most citizens to vote absentee from abroad. So Ms. Luzon will be canceling classes and crossing an ocean to try to make her voice heard.

She is far from alone in making the trip.

Uriel Guy, a software engineer in New York, recalled that at a Rosh Hashana dinner he attended last month, "out of the seven Israelis there, all of them were going to vote." It will be Mr. Guy's first time voting in Israel since moving to New York in 2013. He has asked his siblings there to pick for him among the different opposition parties, because they are the ones "who will have to actually live with the consequences."

According to the London-based Institute for Jewish Policy Research, some 630,000 Israeli citizens live abroad, the equivalent of about 6 percent of the country's population. The American-Israel

Continued on Page A8

Legal Backlash Is Forcing Big Changes on Internet Behemoths

By CECILIA KANG

WASHINGTON — For decades, tech giants grew at breakneck speeds as Congress struggled to keep pace with the consequences of the companies' rapidly booming businesses.

But a new de facto regulatory regime has emerged over the past year as courts clobber the biggest internet companies. And for the first time, their product designs and advertising models — which critics say treat users as products — are costing the companies serious money.

The latest blow came on Wednesday, when a New Mexico judge ordered Meta, which owns Facebook, Instagram and WhatsApp, to pay a record $25 billion penalty for abusing consumer privacy. In a 20-page ruling, the judge scolded the company for deceiving consumers and allowing their data to be harvested by the political consulting firm Cambridge Analytica.

"Facebook's misrepresentations about users' control of their data were not isolated incidents, but rather a systematic pattern of deception at the core of Facebook's business model," wrote Judge Francis J. Mathew of the State District Court in Santa Fe.

Court Orders to Alter Practices and Pay Up

The decision, and others like it, amounts to a comeuppance for tech behemoths, whose fortunes have been built on the business model of winning the attention — and data — of users. Now, trials and court decisions have laid bare many of the allegations over deceptive and harmful business practices that critics have said long propelled the companies' growth.

New consumer guardrails are emerging through the courts' record financial penalties and orders of changes to designs of the companies' technologies, legal experts said.

"We're witnessing an inflection point in the regulation of social media," said Nora Engstrom, a professor of law at Stanford. "Courts, not Congress, are promoting accountability and forcing concrete change."

The changes stem from thousands of lawsuits filed against Meta, Google, Apple, Amazon, TikTok and others by individuals, schools, and state and federal officials. Their claims include that the

Continued on Page A19



INTERNATIONAL A4-9

The Proud Smuggler
A chef in South Africa borrows ideas and ingredients from foreign cuisines, hoping to counter xenophobia. PAGE A4

Protests Mushroom in Europe
Exasperated at what they see as a bleak future, young people have demonstrated in at least eight countries. PAGE A5

BUSINESS B1-5

Zuckerberg's Wealth Tax Plan
The billionaire told Meta's board that he planned to sell his Silicon Valley home. The company remade its stock structure to help him pay the tax. PAGE B1

Health Cost Pushed on Workers
Surveys show companies are moving more of the burden to their employees via premiums and deductibles. PAGE B1

OBITUARIES B11-12

'Invaluable' Ex-Editor at Times
John Geddes oversaw The New York Times's turbulent transition into a digital operation. He was 74. PAGE B11



NATIONAL A10-19

Forces Shaping the Midterms
Four battleground congressional districts in Pennsylvania reveal fault lines that are echoing nationwide. PAGE A12

A Flood of A.I. Political Ads
Republicans have used generated content more often than Democrats, from subtle changes to deepfakes. PAGE A10

WEEKEND ARTS C1-12

An Earthier Brancusi
The artist obsessed with flight emerges as a craftsman enamored of the sweaty satisfactions of stone and wood in a MoMA show of rare artworks, photos, films and tools from Paris. PAGE C1

Filmmaker's Follow-Up
In "Possible Love," his first movie since the celebrated 2018 drama "Burning," the South Korean director Lee Chang-dong focuses on two couples from very different worlds. PAGE C1

OPINION A20-21

Jamelle Bouie PAGE A20



SPORTS B6-10

Baseball's Big Little Markets
Tampa Bay and Milwaukee are set to open the World Series. Their formula for success leaves their peers with no more excuses, our columnist writes. PAGE B6

0 354613 9